small businessmen, and agriculturists. As N. Vaghul observes, ‘Talwar’s greatest contribution was making the bank aware of its social responsibilities to both small-scale industries and agriculture.’[2]

More importantly, the future of the bank was always on his mind. How would the bank cope with its ever increasing branches? This question ultimately led him to initiate and implement the first major organizational restructuring of the bank. As the Chairman, Talwar focused largely on policy issues, leaving routine banking operations to his Managing Directors. Another important contribution by Talwar was putting in place systems to ensure the end-use of bank funds and a comprehensive analysis of corporate balance sheets well in advance of the RBI’s norms for credit analysis of large advances. Talwar also believed that the ‘customer is king’ and in 1975, a working group was appointed with him at its helm to study the problem of customer service in banks. An interim report was submitted in August 1975. Talwar could not submit a final report due to his premature departure from the bank, a story which will be told in the later part of this Chapter.

The multi-volume history of the SBI, the bank’s labour of active remembrance, also owes much to Talwar, who in addition to his skills as a banker, also possessed a sense of history. In 1975, Talwar asked D.N. Ghosh, then with the Ministry of Finance, to find a suitable person to write the history of the bank. Ghosh consulted Prof. Bhabatosh Datta, who suggested the name of Amiya Kumar Bagchi. Datta had been a member of the committee under whose direction the first history of the RBI had been written. Bagchi accepted on condition that he would be solely in charge with no committee breathing down his neck. Under Talwar’s direction, the bank provided all assistance and Bagchi produced four volumes of history (i.e. the first volume in two parts, *The Presidency Banks and the Indian Economy, 1876–1914*, and the official Volume 2 of the history). Bagchi severed his connection with the bank in 1999 because of irreconcilable differences with the management about the scope and publication dateline of the third volume on the Imperial Bank. This was completed by Abhik Ray, Bagchi’s protégé in the history project and an officer of the SBI, who had been one of the first to join Bagchi.[3] Ray also wrote Vol. 4 of the SBI history which deals with the period from 1955 to 1980.